The merchant network flourished until it received its first jolt around the middle of the 18th century with the collapse of the Safavid Empire and Nadir Shah's invasion of Delhi. This led to significant relocations towards the east and south, especially to Shikarpur, where merchants slowly began to reassemble their mercantile strength. The connections with central Asia remained strong and extended till Russia, in the port city of Astrakhan by the Caspian Sea. With the Russian conquest of Tashkent in 1865, a new administrative policy was drawn, one that seriously restricted the scope of Indian mercantile activities.[31] This attitude was shaped by concerns of growing Indian ownership of agricultural land, much like the later experience of the Chettiars in Burma. Along with the expansion of the Russian empire in central Asia, the mercantile diaspora of Punjab began to recede to negligible numbers by the middle of the 20th century. Unlike the Chettiars, however, they were able to relocate their wealth in time.[32] The Partition in 1947 was the next shock that led to much devastation and the influx of a large number of entrepreneurs into the Indian side of Punjab as refugees, who then played an important role in establishing manufacturing clusters in Punjab, especially the bicycle industry.[33]

A different wave of Punjabi migration around Hoshiarpur began to extend within the Indian subcontinent, and to the world in the second half of the 19th century, often tied up with the Great Indian Migration Wave of labour. In addition to mercantile groups like the Khatris and Aroras, this included the Jat Sikh and non-Sikh peasant groups who migrated as soldiers, traders and entrepreneurs. Punjabi mercantile migration within India in the 20th century was associated with commercial towns and big cities such as Mumbai. The migration of Punjabi capital was instrumental in the development of Bollywood and the establishment of several industrial enterprises, such as Mahindra's automotive venture. From the beginning of the 20th century, and accelerating towards the end of it, Canada and the US also became major magnets of Punjabi migration. There, the road from agriculture and labour work towards entrepreneurship was slow and uneven but not uncommon.[34] For instance, Didar Singh Bains, a descendant of a family drawn from Hoshiarpur to the US in the early 20th century, would